

A pixel art illustration of a forest scene. In the foreground, two hikers are walking along a path. The hiker on the left is wearing a red hat and a blue shirt, carrying a backpack. The hiker on the right is wearing a blue shirt and blue pants, also carrying a backpack. They are surrounded by tall, dark trees with dense green foliage. The sky is visible in the background, showing a mix of blue and pinkish-purple hues, suggesting a sunset or sunrise. The overall style is reminiscent of early computer graphics or video game sprites.

APPALACHIAN TRAIL · INTERACTIVE WEBSITE

A Trail Tale

A live-updating, interactive account of a 2,200-mile thru-hike - every pixel, note, and line of code built from the ground up.

2022 · ORIGINAL WEB EXPERIENCE · AWARD-WINNING

Something the internet hadn't seen in a while

Exhausted by the pay-to-play internet, my brothers and I set out to make something simply enjoyable: a first-of-its-kind, live-updating interactive blog of our Appalachian Trail thru-hike. Every sound, pixel, note, and line of code that brings it to life, we made ourselves.

ROLE

Co-creator - concept, writing & art direction

TEAM

Alex, Adam (code) & Andy (design) Moliski

MEDIUM

Custom website · pixel art · original score

RECOGNITION

FWA Site of the Day & Month · Reddit front page

Live-updating

Interactive

Hand-drawn scenes

Original music

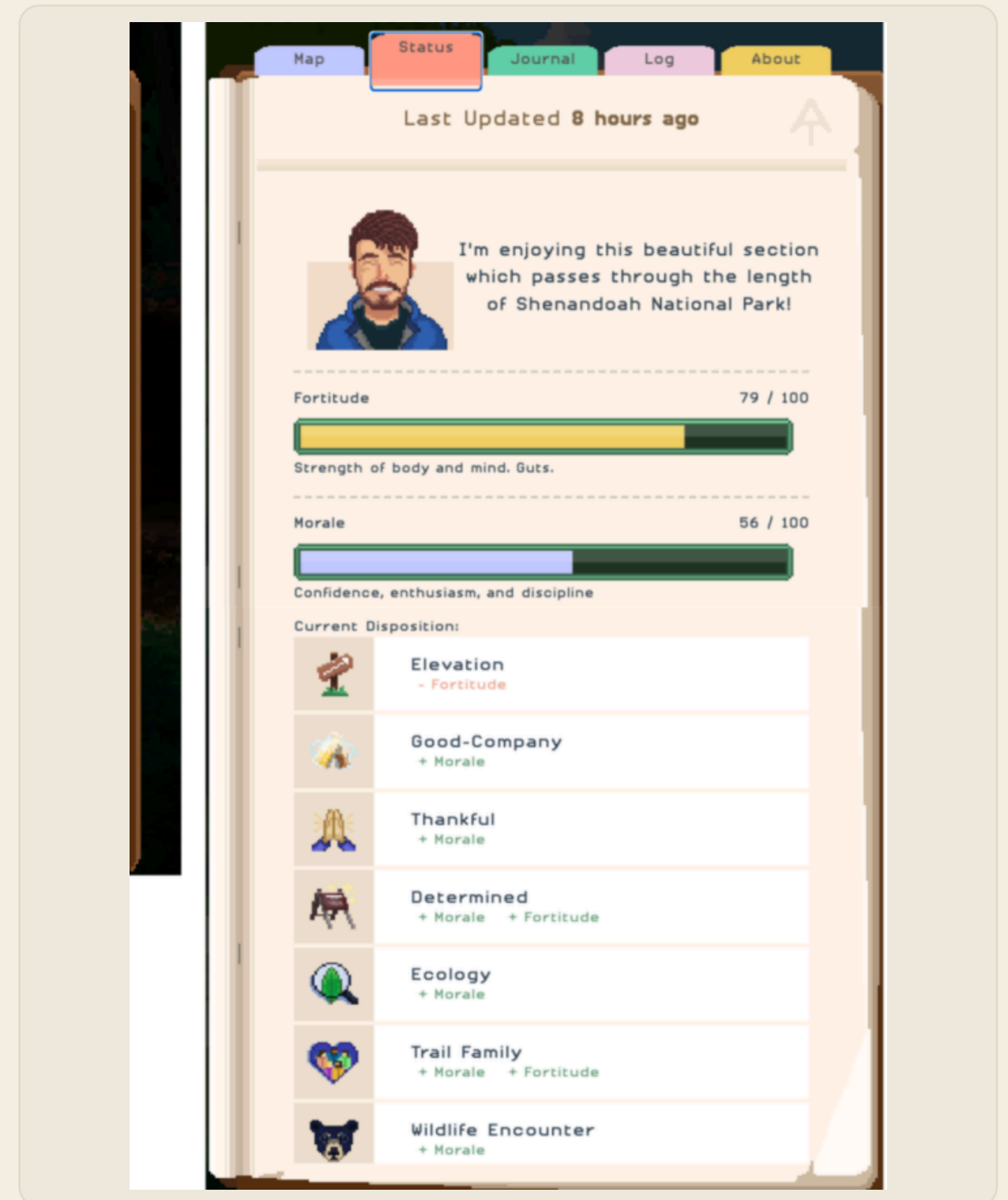
Real-time weather

Mood mechanics

Follow along - almost like a video game

The experience is grounded in two very real stats: Fortitude and Morale. As we hiked and met the trail - a bird (nature +), a heavy pack (encumbered -), a steep climb (elevation -) - our stats shifted in real time.

That mood drove our character's walking animation and the music, so you didn't read how we felt - you saw and heard it. Coffees counted, miles logged, a map tracking every step north.



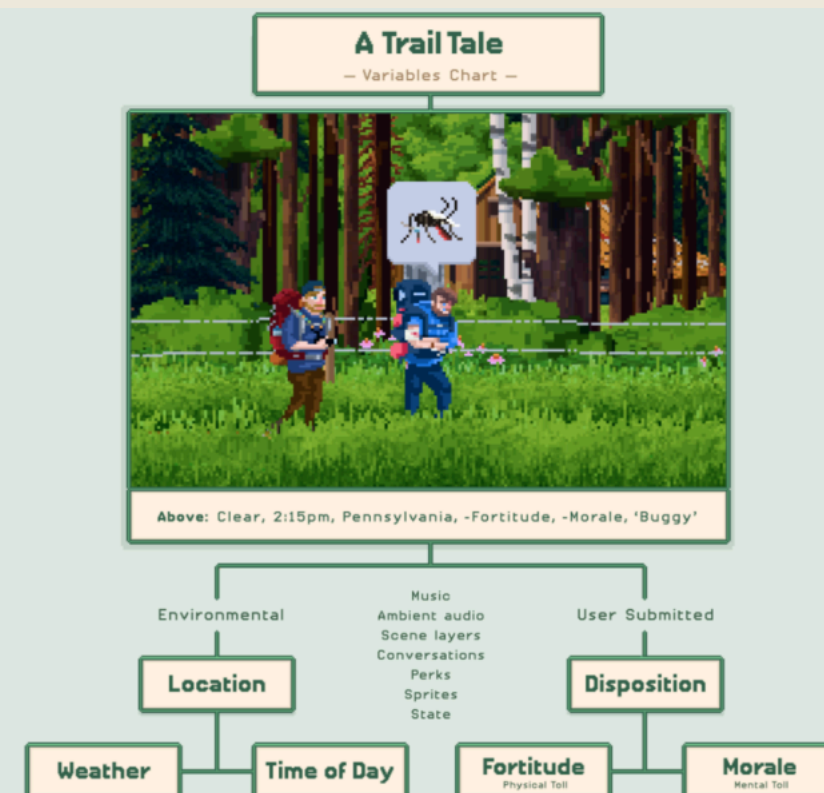
WEATHER & SCENE

The trail cuts through dozens of biomes, so we hand-built scenes that scroll for 15+ minutes each. Real-time weather and time of day come along too - you catch the same golden hour we did.

A programmatic path

Behind the calm surface is a web of logic. Location and disposition feed weather, time of day, fortitude, and morale - which cascade into the scene, the music, and the character on screen.

There were a lot of flowcharts. Here's the general gist.



RECEPTION

It found its people

23.5k

upvotes · Reddit front page

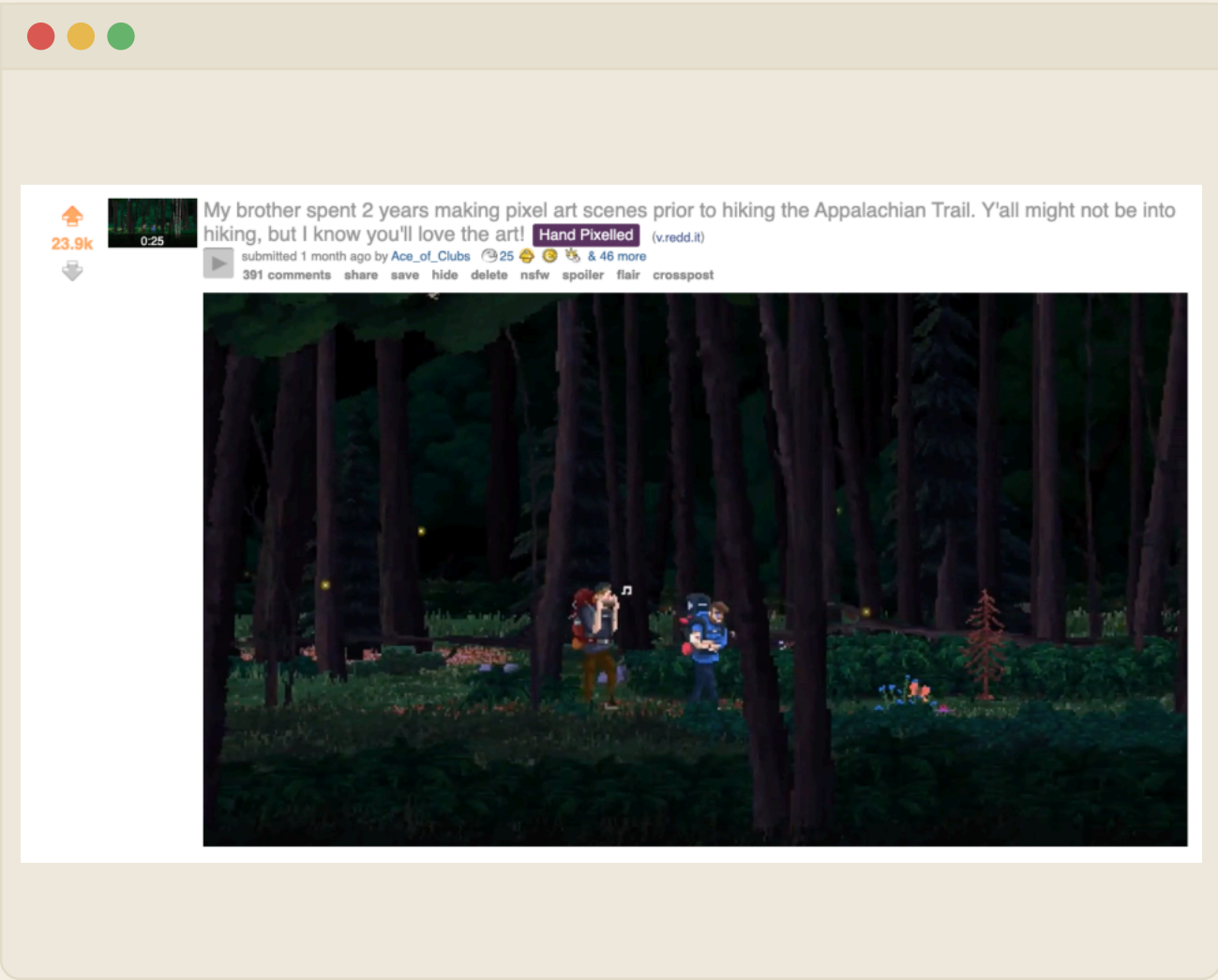
500+

daily visitors

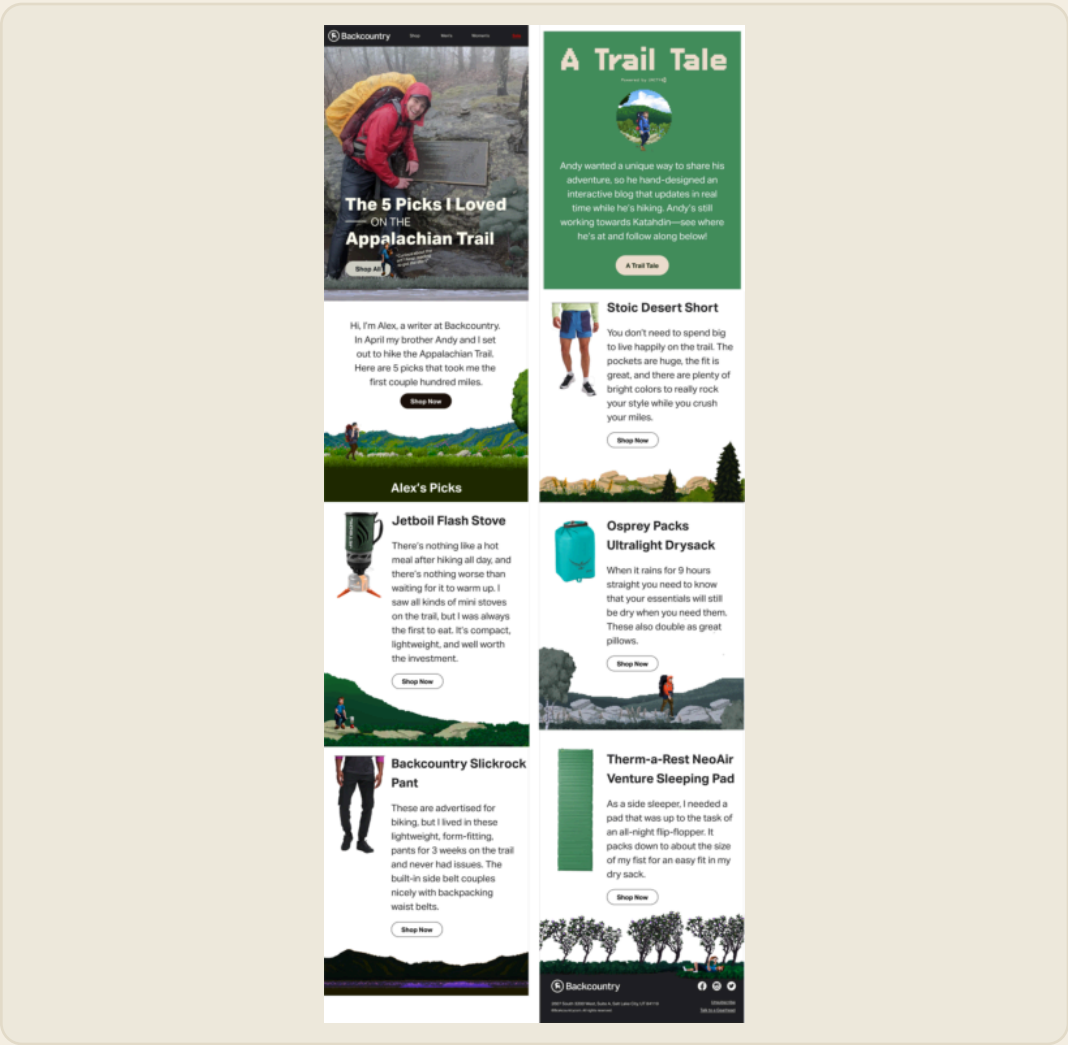
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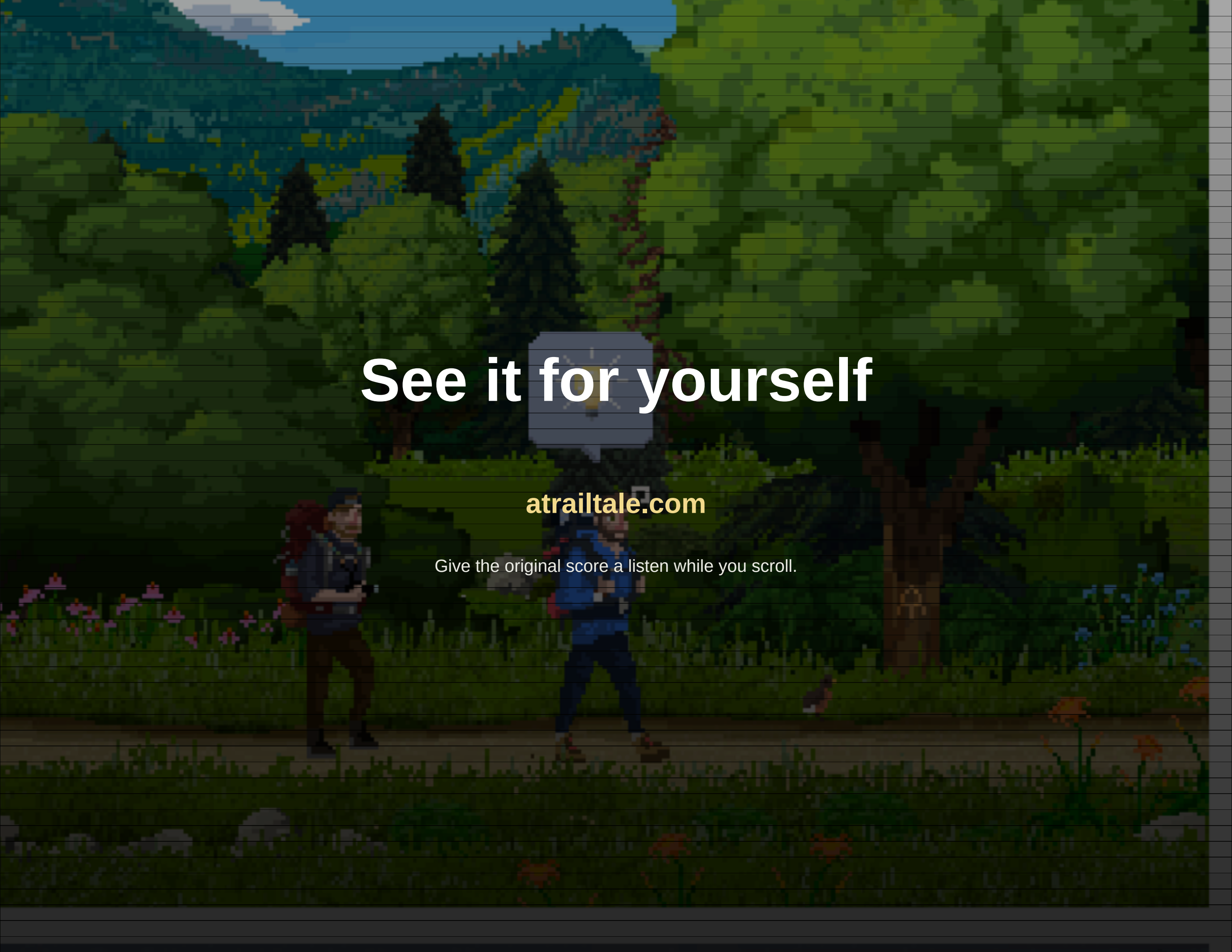
Site of the Day & Month

Front page of Reddit



Backcountry's dedicated email feature



The background is a pixel art illustration of a lush green forest. In the foreground, two hikers are walking on a dirt path. The hiker on the left is wearing a grey shirt, brown pants, and a red backpack. The hiker on the right is wearing a blue shirt, dark pants, and a red backpack. They are both looking towards the right. In the background, there are several tall, green trees and a blue sky with a few white clouds. A speech bubble with a yellow star inside is positioned above the hiker on the right.

See it for yourself

atrailtale.com

Give the original score a listen while you scroll.